Tracking city commitments

How might we help residents see what progress a municipality has made on a public commitment, and what's still unclear?

Build a working proof of concept that a municipality could realistically pilot. It can be a web app, data tool, map, dashboard or another format. A municipal leader should be able to use it without your team in the room.

The problem

Municipalities make many public pledges (strategic plans, housing pledges, budget promises) and set targets, but residents can struggle to find out what has happened since. Progress information may be scattered, outdated, or difficult to compare with the original promise. Reporting could appear in annual reports, committee updates, budget documents, and the occasional dashboard, each with its own format and timeline. Targets also change. Deadlines shift, measures are redefined and plans are replaced, which makes it hard to tell whether a commitment is on track, delayed or quietly dropped. Residents rarely get a clear answer to a simple question: *what did the city promise, and is it happening?*

A commitment needs a clear target, deadline and measure before progress can be assessed. For example, Toronto's goals include reducing emissions from City-owned buildings by 60% from 2008 levels by 2030. Its facilities plan also sets a 37 MW renewable-energy goal for 2030. [1, 2] The City publishes utility data and an inventory of renewable installations, but the datasets have different coverage and limitations. An installation is evidence of an action; it does not by itself establish energy generated, emissions reduced or achievement of a corporate target. [3, 4]

The federal Housing Accelerator Fund is a second example. According to the Parliamentary Budget Officer, CMHC had committed $4.37 billion across 230 agreements, in which governments agreed to carry out 1,744 initiatives toward a target of 112,000 additional homes by 2028. Pledges like these are published in different places and reported on different schedules, so a resident has no single place to see whether a promise is being kept.

Residents, journalists and community groups who want to hold a city to account must piece together evidence from scattered documents. Even staff can find it hard to give a clear status across many commitments and departments.

There is a need for tools that link a commitment to its measures, show progress over time and are honest about gaps: where data is missing, the measure is vague or responsibility sits with another level of government.

How common and persistent it is

- In 2019, municipalities across Ontario and Canada declared climate emergencies. Several, including Toronto, Mississauga, Ottawa and Vancouver, have since acknowledged they are not on track to meet their 2030 emissions targets.

- A University of Waterloo study of 38 Ontario municipalities found only **7** published a stand-alone sustainability report and only **2** published a climate change report, a significant gap between planning and reporting (Municipal Sustainability and Climate Planning: A Study of 38 Canadian Local Governments' Plans and Reports, 2023)
- In Ottawa, a 2023 progress report labelled most of the climate plan's priorities "off track." The city's auditor general later found accountability for targets hadn't been formalized across departments (City of Ottawa Climate Change Master Plan, 2023).

Questions to investigate

- What happens when commitments outlive councils? Plans can cover decades but councils change every four years.
- How will you handle inconsistency in reporting and lack of consensus over terms like 'in progress'?
- Who is responsible for delivering and reporting on a commitment when several departments or partners are involved?
- What evidence distinguishes actions taken from measurable progress toward a target?
- How can reporting make delays, setbacks, missing evidence and uncertainty clear and understandable?
- What can existing municipal dashboards teach us about tracking commitments across multiple plans, and where do gaps remain?

What it costs

- When residents can't see follow-through, they assume nothing happened.
- Without clear tracking, councils find out too late that commitments are slipping.
- Staff spend time rebuilding progress reports for each request, committee or audit.

Who you are designing for

Primary users. Residents seeking a clear account of what a municipality promised and what evidence shows about progress. Community organizations advocating for specific goals.

Municipal users. Staff responsible for delivering commitments, reporting results and answering questions from council.

Other stakeholders. Councillors, community organizations, journalists and agencies contributing to delivery. Partners such as chambers of commerce, school boards and nonprofits who share responsibility for outcomes. Funders and senior governments that attach conditions to commitments.

What success looks like

- Users can find the original commitment, responsible organization, target and deadline where available.
- Progress claims link to dated evidence and use clear, consistent status definitions.
- The tool makes missing information and uncertainty visible without treating them as proof of failure. Flags what is unclear, such as missing data, vague wording or no recent update

- A municipal leader can use the working tool independently, understand the status and see what evidence or follow-up is needed.
- A record of how commitments have changed over time
- A realistic plan for keeping the information current

Constraints

- Preserve the original commitment and record revisions. Distinguish activity, spending, and outputs from the intended outcome.
- Use comparable measures, time periods and organizational boundaries. Do not calculate target progress without a suitable baseline.
- Distinguish “no recent evidence” from “no progress”. Show the measurement date as well as the publication or retrieval date.
- Do not attribute every change to municipal action. Explain important data gaps and other factors that could affect the result.

Two public datasets to explore

You may use other public data that better supports your solution. Record your sources and dates, and make data limitations visible.

1. **Annual Energy Consumption City Owned and Operated Buildings (City of Toronto data and downloads)**

Provides property and utility meter records for a defined group of facilities. Compare energy use across consistent buildings and periods. The file has no direct emissions totals or established comparable 2008 baseline, so energy trends alone cannot measure progress against the emissions target.

2. **Renewable Energy Installations (City of Toronto data and downloads)**

Includes installation locations, system types, dates and sizes. Check technologies and units before adding capacities; installed capacity is not annual generation.

Other potential data sources are municipal strategic plans, climate action plans and progress reports; council minutes and staff reports; budget documents; existing municipal dashboards; open data portals.

Explain your thinking

Show who the tool serves, why you designed it this way and how you checked its outputs. Include clear instructions, source links and any assumptions. Explain what a municipality would need to test or add before piloting it. If you use AI, make its role and limitations clear.

Background sources

[1] City of Toronto. Greening City Operations

[2] City of Toronto. Transforming City Buildings and Facilities

[3] City of Toronto. Annual Energy Consumption

[4] City of Toronto. Renewable Energy Installations